

Teaching Tech Together

Motivation



Greg Wilson
<https://third-bit.com>



All art from openclipart.org (open license)

Learning Objectives

1. Describe the difference between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation and explain their impact on learning and retention.
2. Summarize the three main motivating factors for neurotypical adult learners.
3. Summarize the three main demotivating factors for neurotypical adult learners.
4. Explain why bystander (intervention) training is an effective way to ensure inclusivity and the role of scenarios and role play in acquiring these skills.
5. Describe and justify the steps an instructor should take if they have to eject a learner from their class.

Motivation

Intrinsic	Doing this for my own reasons
Extrinsic	Doing this because I have to

The single strongest predictor of whether an adult learns something or not is their motivation, and any discussion of motivation has to start with the difference between *intrinsic* and *extrinsic* motivation. Learning to play the ukulele because you've always wanted to is intrinsic; learning because you're in Grade 5 and the teacher said so is extrinsic, and unlikely to stick.

Positive: Self-Efficacy



I am in control of my own life.

First and most importantly, adults want to be in control of their own lives - they don't like to jump through hoops. Self-efficacy is the driving force behind self-paced online training: it allows people (well, those privileged enough to have free time) to learn what they want and when they want.

Positive: Utility



This will help me meet my goals.

Utility is the second big motivator for adults. Is this useful? Will it help me meet my goals? (It's important to note that there are many kinds of utility, just as people have many different kinds of goals—learning the ukulele probably won't help you find a job, but that's not why you're doing it.)

Positive: Community

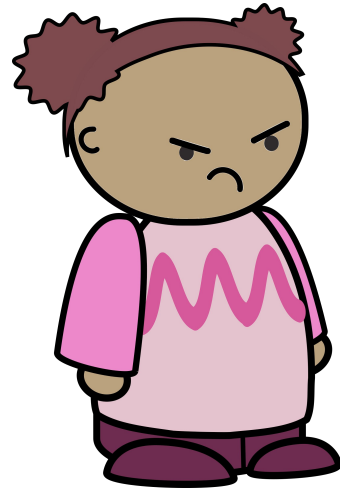


People I know are
learning this with me.

The third motivator is community. People like to do what their friends, neighbors, and colleagues are doing, and they like to do things together - this is why the best predictor of whether someone actually uses a gym membership is whether or not someone they know is going with them.

Negative: Unpredictability

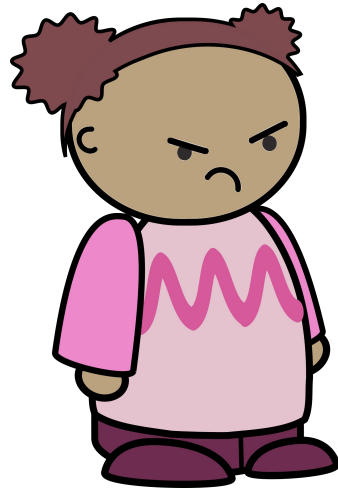
What I do doesn't seem to affect the outcome.



Now let's look at demotivators. The most important is unpredictability: if taking actions works some of the time, but not other times, people give up trying because there's no point. This is called *learned helplessness*.

Negative: Unfairness

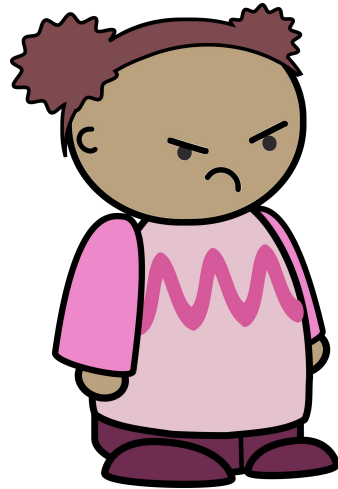
The teacher plays favorites.



A second big demotivator is unfairness. Studies have shown that if people believe the game is rigged, everyone will do less well—even those that the game is rigged in favor of.

Negative: Indifference

Nobody cares.



The third of our demotivators is indifference—the feeling that nobody cares if you succeed or not. It’s easy for students to feel this way in large classes or when learning online, but it’s also easy for instructors to give this impression even when they’re teaching one-to-one.

The Perils of Pre-Assessment

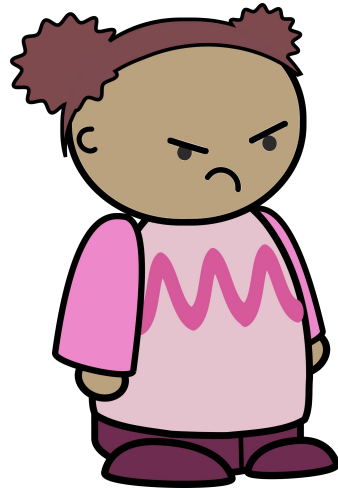


Note: it's tempting to pre-assess learners to stream them. However, doing this can give a misleading signal because of *false beginners*. It can also demotivate people who have exam anxiety and don't believe that the curriculum will actually be adjusted to them. Members of marginalized groups are particularly at risk from this.

There Is No “Outside”

If poor inner-city children consistently outscored children from wealthy suburban homes on standardized tests, is anyone naive enough to believe that we would still insist on using these tests as indicators of success?

– Kenneth Wesson



Motivation and demotivation don't just happen in class. As Sahlberg and others have pointed out, one of the reasons other countries have failed to replicate Finland's very successful school system is that they're not willing to address all of the out-of-school factors that determine whether learners are willing and able to succeed.

The Bad News

Neither the training programs that most companies put all workers through nor the grievance procedures that they have implemented are helping to solve the problem of sexual harassment in the workplace. In fact, both tend to increase worker disaffection and turnover.

— [Dobbin & Klev](#)

Most attempts to fix this problem have had no effect.

The Good News

Bystander-intervention training...is the most promising alternative we've come across...

Training delivered exclusively to managers is also quite effective.

— [Dobbin & Klev](#)

However, training people how to intervene *does* make things better.

If You Have to Eject Someone

0. Remind everyone of the Code of Conduct.
1. Get a witness.
2. Tell other learners that you removed the offender.
3. Write it down.
4. Talk to a friend.

...and then share your experience!

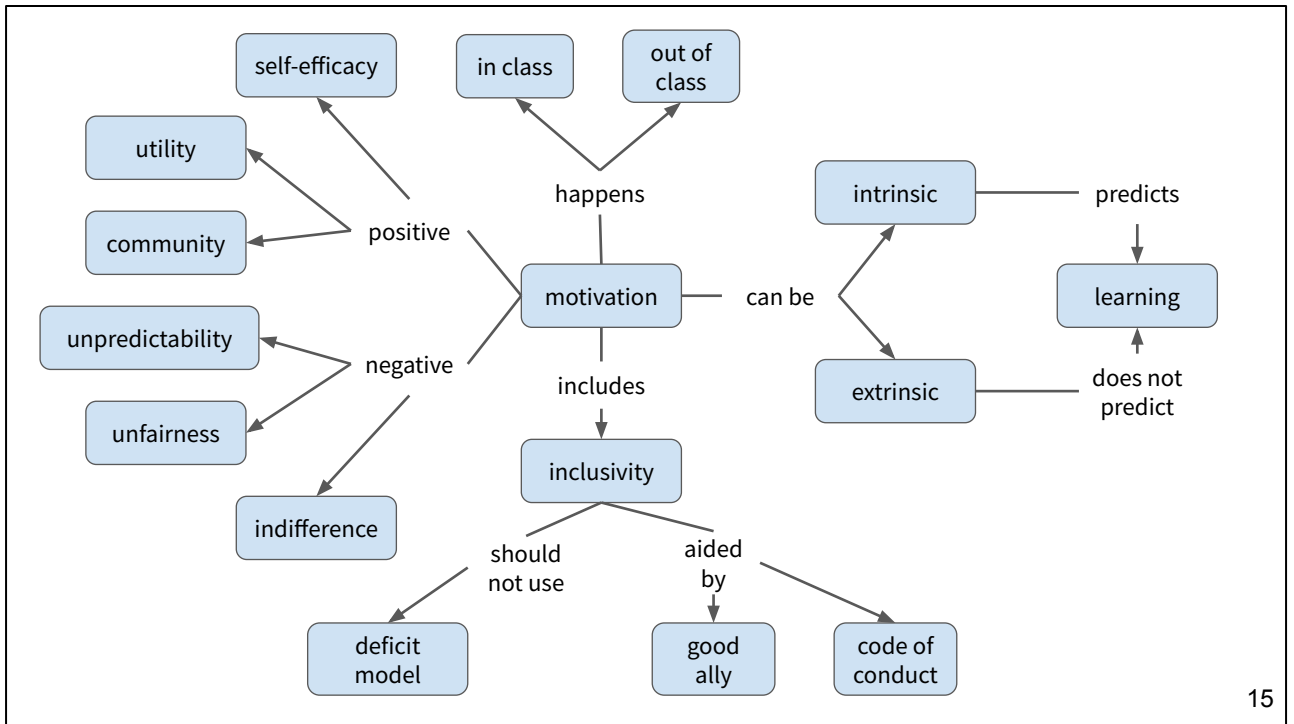
If you have to eject someone from your class, follow these steps (where step 0 happens before class so that they can't say, "But you didn't tell me.")

Exercise

A student with an attention disorder needs to talk loudly to themselves in order to concentrate. Other students complain that this is distracting. What steps do you take, in order, to manage this?



A student with an attention disorder needs to talk loudly to themselves in order to concentrate. Other students complain that this is distracting. What steps do you take, in order, to manage this?



Concept map for motivation and demotivation.